

Southern caracara
Caracara plancus

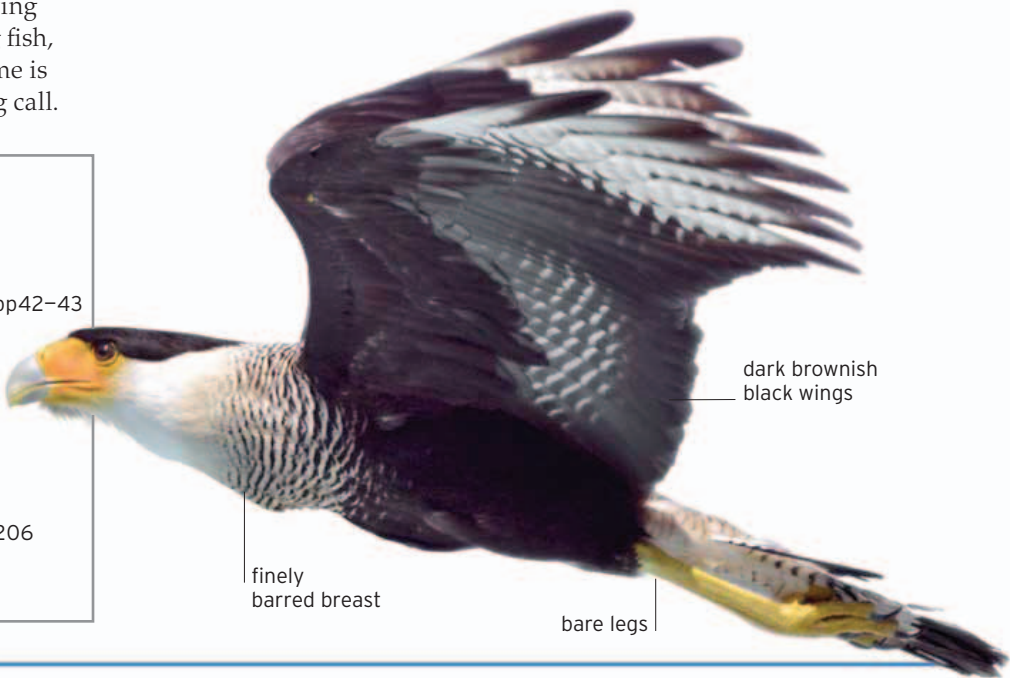
- ↔ 20–23 in (51–58 cm)
- 📍 South America
- ⊗ Common

Although a member of the highly aerial falcon family, this large, crested, mainly dark bird of prey spends most of its time on the ground, scavenging for carrion like a crow. It has long legs with strong feet, well suited to walking and investigating carcasses. An opportunistic scavenger, it will often dig for food or chase other birds, including raptors and vultures, to steal it. It also preys on live frogs and reptiles, as well

as feeding on road kill, rotting vegetables, dead and dying fish, worms, and insects. Its name is based on its harsh, cackling call.

Other species

- Andean condor
Vultur gryphus » p112
- Bald eagle
Haliaeetus leucocephalus » pp42–43
- Golden eagle
Aquila chrysaetos » p162
- Lammergeier
Gypaetus barbatus » p183
- Peregrine falcon
Falco peregrinus » p144
- Secretary bird
Sagittarius serpentarius » p206
- Turkey vulture
Cathartes aura » p56



Cranes and relatives
Order Gruiformes

Common crane
Grus grus

- ↔ 4 ft (1.2 m)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, N. Africa
- ⊗ Common

A tall, long-legged, elegant gray bird with a red spot on top of its black-and-white head, the common crane can gather in huge flocks in winter to feed on crops such as grain. In spring, it moves to

wetlands to pair up and breed, each pair performing a courtship display in which they walk in circles with wings raised, bobbing and pirouetting, while picking up small objects and tossing them over their heads. The performance is accompanied by loud, trumpeting calls, given with their bills pointing skyward. The sound is amplified by an enlarged windpipe that is fused with the breastbone.

Sandhill crane
Grus canadensis

- ↔ 4 ft (1.2 m)
- 📍 North America, NE. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Similar to the common crane, but with no black on its head, this is a widespread species with several distinctive subspecies. Like most cranes, it is an opportunistic feeder, gleaning a range of plant foods and prey from the ground. In winter, the birds that breed in Alaska and Canada migrate southward, gathering at stopover sites and wintering grounds in large flocks.

Limpkin
Aramus guarauna

- ↔ 22–28 in (56–71 cm)
- 📍 SE. US (Florida), Central and South America
- ⊗ Common

Named for its curious limping walk, this wetland bird has brown, white-speckled plumage and a long, curved, slender bill, which it uses to pry aquatic snails from their shells. However, it also eats other prey such as freshwater mussels, insects, and frogs. The male is highly territorial, defending his patch with loud calls and fighting off intruders and rivals.

Corncrake
Crex crex

- ↔ 11–12 in (28–30 cm)
- 📍 Europe, W. to C. Asia, SE. Africa
- ⊗ Common

Superbly camouflaged by its streaky brown plumage, the corncrake is hard to see in its grassland habitat. But where it is still common, the male is easily heard in spring as he raises his head to advertise his territory with the loud, rasping, “krek-krek” call reflected in the species’ scientific name. Although

widespread in summer across Europe and western Asia, it has been badly hit by modern farming practices involving the destruction of old, species-rich grasslands.



Kori bustard
Ardeotis kori

- ↔ 4 ft (1.2 m)
- 📍 E. and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Near threatened

The kori bustard is a very large, long-legged, mainly gray and brown bird of dry grasslands and deserts, where it typically lives alongside large grazing animals and preys on the insects disturbed by their hoofs. It also inhabits areas that have recently been burned, eating the new shoots of grass and insects exposed by the lack of vegetation. Adult males may weigh up to 44 lb (20 kg), making them among the heaviest of all flying birds. Like its relatives,

however, it lives on the ground and is reluctant to fly unless in serious danger. The males perform dramatic courtship displays to attract the much smaller females, inflating their throats like feathery white balloons.

Other species

- Great bustard
Otis tarda » p283
- Gray crowned crane
Balearica regulorum » p189
- Purple gallinule
Porphyrio martinica » p71
- Red-legged seriema
Cariama cristata » p120
- Sarus crane
Grus antigone » p263